

Insects

Long before dinosaurs evolved, Earth was already buzzing with insects. The first insects were tiny, wingless creatures that lived on the ground about 400 million years ago. Later they evolved wings and became the world's first flying animals. Mastering flight made them incredibly successful and they evolved into thousands of new species. Today, they make up three-quarters of all animal species on Earth.

Ants

- **When** 110–130 million years ago (Cretaceous Period) to now
- **Number of species today** More than 12,000 known
- **Diet** Everything from seeds and leaves to fungi and flesh

Ants evolved from wasps that began living in the ground in colonies. They were rare in the age of the dinosaurs but became very common later. Their huge colonies have a single breeding queen and hundreds of workers and soldiers, all of which are wingless females—daughters of the queen.

Bees

- **When** 100 million years ago (Early Cretaceous) to now
- **Number of species today** Nearly 20,000
- **Diet** Nectar, pollen

After flowering plants appeared 125 million years ago, some prehistoric wasps began to feed on flowers instead of preying on other insects, and these became bees. There are now thousands of different types of bee. Some are solitary, but many live in colonies with a single queen. Worker bees rear the young and collect nectar from flowers to store as honey.

35-million-year-old fossil bee



DID YOU KNOW...?

When a bee feeds on a flower, a yellow dust called pollen sticks to its body. When it lands on another flower, the pollen rubs off and causes that flower to produce seeds. This process is known as pollination.

